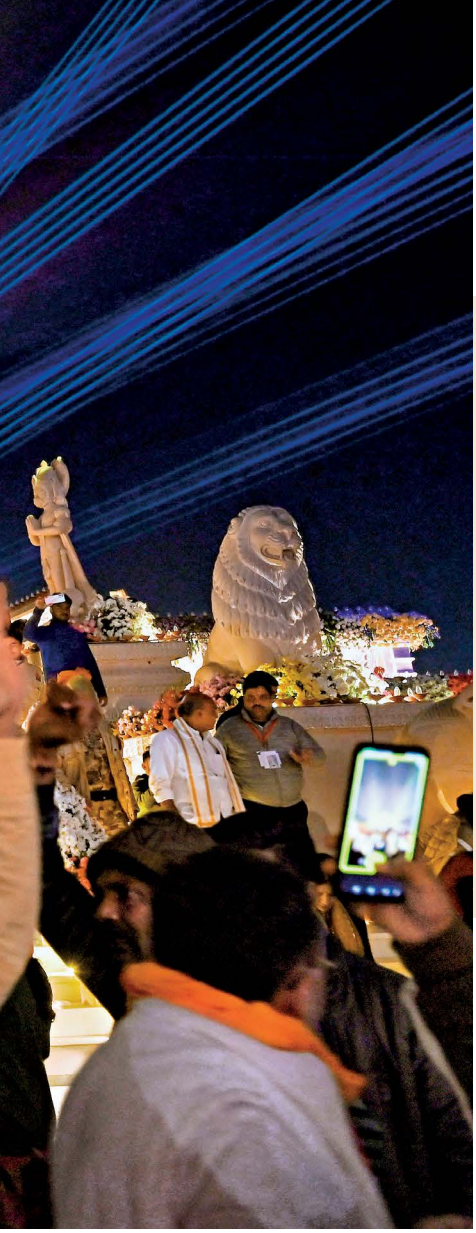


CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Structure and Function

- **A towering edifice in the old northern Nagara style of temple architecture, with eclectic 'pan-India' touches**
- **Intricately carved pink Rajasthani sandstone leads up to a black granite Ram idol, done southern style**
- **The temple's foundation stone contains soil and water collected from numerous pilgrimage sites strewn across India**

As a manifest sign of the psychology of contemporary India—its social and political face, body and self-image—the Ram temple at Ayodhya has few parallels. The opening of its gates seemed to offer a kind of closure on a key chapter in its evolution. For the devout, a moment of spiritual euphoria and fulfilment. For the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party, a key ideological promise embodied in reality. For others, a symbol of the political power that religion wields in modern India—the event calendar, with a prime minister leading a grand *pran pratishtha* three months before a general election, did nothing to allay those stark associations. As it happened, the expected electoral harvests didn't quite materialise, and political well-being resulted because Ram was supplemented with latter-day 'Paltu Rams'. Saffron, notably, lost even in Ayodhya. Nor was closure close at hand for the debate on identity—how 'India', as well as 'Hindu', would define themselves. A long-running epic in itself, one that had wracked the polity to its core for decades, it continued to new chapters. Despite express promises that Ayodhya would clinch the deal in India's bargain with itself.

What that left behind is a many-pillared piece of magniloquence in a collage of traditions: the northern Nagara style of architecture, in pink sandstone from Rajasthan, with a black granite Ram *lalla* idol by a Mysore sculptor, rendered like a southern deity. Also, a medieval holy town yanked to hypermodernity: new roads cutting through its old neural networks of provincial charm, gleaming infrastructure projects, spanking new airport, five-star hotels, and a newly dawned realty bazaar. Not the sort of concern for the past that would have been preferred by heritage conservationists, who fret about the loss of authenticity. Towering over it all is a grand symbol of an indeterminate time, which is at once old and new. Pilgrims gaze at it in awe and then move on to the older Hanuman Garhi temple for the familiar rituals of worship.

The Ram temple was finally born, in all its regal effulgence, to realign the 'here and now' of India with its past

The Ram temple was finally born, in all its regal effulgence, in January 2024. But the essential act it performs is to realign the 'here and now' of India with its past. Which past? The chronology of its birth depends on the observer's eye. The tightest calendar gives you about four years, from the Supreme Court green signal of November 9, 2019. The less de jure gestation period extends from another November 9, this time from 1989—the *shilanyas*—and the cataclysmic Babri Masjid demolition that followed on December 6, 1992. Some will leap back four decades, to the 'appearance' of the Ram idol in the masjid precincts in 1949. Devouts may time-travel all the way back to the Treta Yuga. Those with a less fuzzy historical bent will register the span from the long Buddhist era of Saketa, from circa 600 BC, to the temple-building of 12th century Rajput rulers. Only some of that filtered through in the fraught legal debates that produced more heat than light. Such temperatures provide a conducive habitat to Hindutva, which can be said to have won the day in Ayodhya, despite its own residents deciding otherwise. The temple, in many ways, stands as a mirror reflecting a people's aspirations and complexities. ■